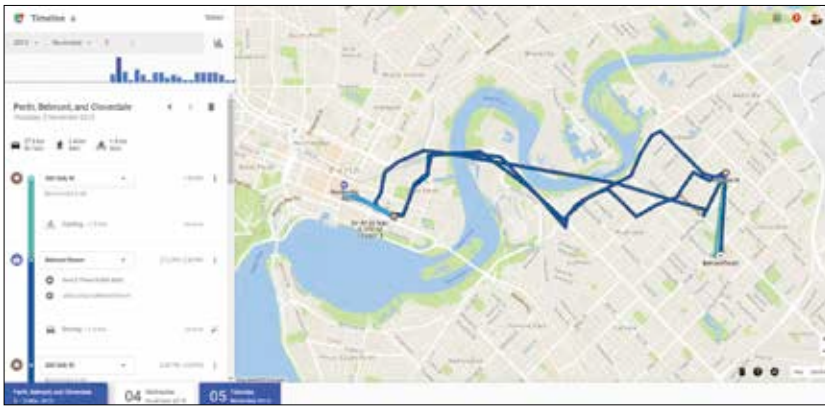
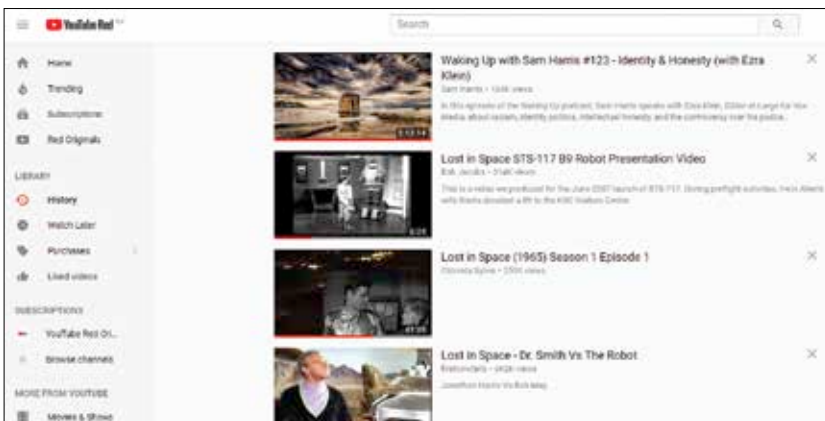




This is me shifting from a temporary house to an apartment in the city two years ago. Not that anyone wants to stalk me, but I should add I don't live in either place anymore.



It has a search history that goes on seemingly forever!

they do let on to, they claim to use a system they call “Differential Privacy” to gather data about you. What this means is that everything you do on an iPhone and how you interact with it is certainly monitored and logged to a small extent, but instead of focussing on you as an individual, it looks at you as a member of a larger group. How large? Depends really, and there’s no reliable source for this. But let’s say it could be as diverse as “male iPhone X users” or as niche as “Male iPhone X users who live in Mumbai and spend over 2 hours a day playing Candy Crush Soda Saga”. You know who you are... all three of you!

In essence, Apple does exactly what Google and Facebook do when looking to improve their services, but Google and Facebook certainly go several steps further because they have to display ads to you.

Now, before you Apple users start jumping up and down rejoicing about how you have been vindicated for selling your kidneys to buy your

phone... remember that Apple is pretty much all about the apps, and it is a pretty important source of revenue to them. Although nowhere close to the revenue that iPhone gets them, their services division is in the second spot with a clear gap over both iPad and Mac revenues.

Apps come with in-app advertising, and who controls the advertising? You got it... the same networks that also tie up with Google and Facebook to deliver personalised advertising. When I go on to a page of an e-tailer, and look at a few products, and then leave (without buying), I start seeing ads for that same product in my Facebook news feed, inside apps on my Android devices, and yes, even inside apps on my Apple devices. It’s not like they don’t know who I am on my Apple devices, because they do, using whatever methods necessary, such as my IP address, or even device data that’s shared with the app itself, such as location services, or contact information... anything, really.

It is the age of big data, and if you have a device connected to the internet, you’re being tracked. Period.

However, it is still true that Apple devices seem to be tracking you less, or at least that’s based on what Apple says, because we have no clear way of accessing what data Apple stores about you to verify this. Until a whistleblower comes forth, we do have to assume that Apple is the least intrusive of all though.

#### 4. E-tailers

This is where Amazon, AliExpress, Ebay, Flipkart and the likes come in. This is a more specific targeting of you, with a more traditional goal of getting you to buy stuff. Simple marketing put on steroids by big data analysis, and with social media and ad networks assisting them. Knowing who you are, what you’ve bought, and then being able to use that to sell you more stuff was always the dream of retail in the decades gone by, and today that’s already a reality.

Not only do they know about what you have bought before on their site, thanks to ad networks and tie-ups, they know what you’ve searched for and also what you have viewed on pretty much any other site. Of course, unlike Facebook, they’re less interested in which political party you support, unless they happen to be selling their flags or something... Still, given that we buy so much stuff online these days, it’s important to mention them. In fact, it’s not just online buying you need to care about, but even offline purchases, or things you never thought would be linked to a profile of you... this is where the next category comes in.

#### 5. Others

Yes, I know I’m leaving out the likes of Microsoft from this, and I’m doing it on purpose, because it just isn’t the behemoth it used to be in either the devices or the advertising front. It’s still a force to be reckoned with in business terms, but that doesn’t really bother you as a consumer unless you have an Office 365 account, or a OneDrive subscription that you backup everything to... like me... Microsoft probably